

these things are properly managed and there is not a single deviation,” says signalling expert Raviprakash Karcherla. While welcoming the increased spending on safety through initiatives like the Rashtriya Rail Sanraksha Kosh (RRSK) with a ₹1-lakh crore corpus, experts say the current pace of modernisation leaves a yawning gap. The government, meanwhile, has drawn flak after a 2021 Comptroller and Auditor General report alleged that a part of the RRSK funds was allegedly diverted to purchase foot massagers and crockery, develop gardens, build toilets, pay salaries and bonuses and erect a flag, among other things. “As safety is not an option, it must be embedded and enforced from the drawing board stage,” states the international safety expert.

18 | There is another challenge. Over the years, the railways has been losing traffic to road transport for short distances and to airlines in the premium long-haul segment. But one of rail’s USPs is safety and convenience, especially for the elderly. “Accidents of this nature severely dent this perception. Apart from the obvious impact of the loss of lives, injuries, economic disruptions, etc., the impact of diversion of traffic to roads especially will have a higher longer-term impact on the Railways,” says Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Senior Director at CRISIL Market Intelligence.

The railways can arrest such a perception from taking hold by maintaining the highest safety standards. Perhaps it can learn a thing or two from the Ministry of Civil Aviation, which since FY15 has aggressively added air traffic controllers in the Airports Authority of India and additional personnel in regulatory bodies. Ironically, it is officials of the Commission of Railway Safety (CRS) that are appointed to the Civil Aviation Safety Agency for their expertise. **BT**

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Zee’s Tense Future

Promoters Subhash Chandra and Punit Goenka have rushed to the SAT to appeal against Sebi’s interim order barring them from holding directorships. Could this episode also impact the merger with Sony?

BY ASHISH RUKHAIYAR



PHOTO BY GETTY IMAGES

► **AN INTENSE BATTLE** raged at the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT). In the one corner were Subhash Chandra, promoter of Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd (ZEEL), and his son Punit Goenka, MD and CEO of ZEEL, and on the other, the capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi). At issue was Sebi’s interim order barring Goenka and Chandra from holding directorships in any listed entity for al-

legedly abusing their positions in the company and siphoning off funds for their own benefit.

A lengthy hearing took place on June 19, but at the day’s end there was no respite for the father-son duo as SAT decided to post the matter for further hearing on June 26 and refused to provide them interim relief.

Sebi’s interim order barring the duo was based on an investigation into allegations related to appropriation of certain